

## 5.7 Vi Editors

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When you hear “editor” in the computing world, you will immediately think of Notepad or MS Word. If you have read thus far, you will be thinking of Kwrite or gedit or Open Office Writer. But these are not of much use to the programmer: he does not need too many fonts or colours or document editing tools. Remember, a program easily stretches into hundreds and even thousand of lines, so what he needs is ease of navigation. He needs to have commands to move through words and lines. That is where a vi editor comes in.

A vi editor is like a text editor made for someone dealing with lots of text. Vi was originally made from two other UNIX-based editors called ex and ed. Ex, especially, was very complicated. This lead the creator of vi, Bill Joy, to develop an easy-to-use editing tool. Vi today is a hot favourite of programmers for its ease of use.

So, why are you being told all this?

No, we don’t expect everyone to be a programmer. But we can tell you that programming is fun! Programmers are as human as you are, and it’s nice to know something about how a program is usually edited. This can also come in handy as you will learn how to edit config files to change the behaviour of Linux. If the file is large, you’re much better off with vi.

At first glance, the vi screen appears cold and unforthcoming. But even though vi is awkward to use for the first few times, once you get used to it, it enables fast and simple editing. You cannot use vi properly before knowing at least a handful of commands. A key concept in vi that enables efficient navigation around the text is that you can combine an *action* (such as delete, copy to buffer, capitalise, etc.) with a *movement* (go to line 63, go to the next occurrence of “digit,” go to the fifth occurrence of “K” in this line, etc.). You can set the action to be performed on all lines (or characters) between two points. The points are defined by the cursor position.